

Curbside Executive Summary

Non Confidential Executive Summary | September 2026

Website: curbsidescore.com | Contact: [Name and cell phone]

University: [University and degree program] | Sector: Consumer automotive software

Business Summary

Curbside helps used-car buyers decide which Facebook Marketplace vehicles deserve their time and attention. Its browser extension evaluates the listing a buyer is already viewing, compares the asking price with relevant nearby listings, identifies warning signs, and organizes questions for the seller. The purpose is to make private-party car shopping easier to understand before a buyer schedules a visit, negotiates a price, or pays for an inspection.

The business combines a free entry point with paid evaluation packs and a monthly plan for active shoppers. The initial strategy is to serve budget-conscious buyers who compare several vehicles during a concentrated shopping period. Curbside aims to earn trust through clear explanations, visible uncertainty, and useful comparisons, then convert a portion of those shoppers into paying customers. The immediate objective is to establish reliable product performance and repeatable customer acquisition before expanding distribution.

Customer Problem

A private-party listing presents an asking price and a seller's description, but often leaves the buyer to interpret the most important details. Mileage, trim, title disclosures, local supply, and missing information can all change whether a vehicle is worth pursuing. A low asking price may reflect a genuine opportunity, a condition problem, or a misleading listing. Buyers must assemble context across multiple listings and research tools, often without knowing which comparisons are appropriate.

The resulting problem is both financial and practical: shoppers can waste time contacting unsuitable sellers, overlook questions that matter, or negotiate without a clear reference point. Curbside reduces the work needed to screen a shortlist. It brings pricing context and reasons for caution into the browsing experience, while directing buyers toward further verification when the available information is incomplete.

Why Customers Would Pay

The proposed value exchange is a modest software purchase in return for faster, more informed screening of a much larger purchase. A shopper reviewing ten or twenty cars has repeated opportunities to use the product. Non-expiring packs accommodate occasional buyers, while a monthly option supports intensive shopping. Ten free evaluations let customers assess usefulness before paying.

Willingness to pay remains a hypothesis to validate through completed purchases and customer interviews. The key evidence will be conversion after free use, the number of listings evaluated per shopping episode, and whether buyers report that the results changed their shortlist or questions. The launch plan prioritizes these measures over downloads alone. Curbside's promise is better decision support; it does not guarantee savings, identify every scam, or replace an inspection.

Product and Technical Readiness

Product and Services

Curbside runs as a Chrome extension supported by a web application and evaluation service. A user initiates an evaluation from a Marketplace vehicle listing. The system captures relevant listing information and comparable listings, then presents an explanation of price, vehicle risk, listing concerns, and negotiation context. Saved evaluations help users revisit vehicles and compare their options throughout a shopping period.

The pricing approach uses observed asking prices and vehicle characteristics to estimate a comparison benchmark. Screening logic excludes unsuitable comparisons, including some financing down payments presented as prices. The experience also incorporates model-level recall and complaint information, disclosed title concerns, qualitative issues to investigate, and alternative listings when available. Recall context is not confirmation of a particular vehicle's repair history, and a listing-based flag is not a verified finding about a seller.

The product's practical benefit is the connection between a result and its explanation. A buyer should be able to understand what supports the price comparison, what information is missing, and which follow-up questions matter. When the evidence is weak, the product must make that weakness visible and avoid presenting a precise estimate as certainty.

Evidence and Remaining Development

The repository contains implemented listing capture, evaluation, saved results, accounts, pricing plans, and payment integration code. These components establish that the venture has progressed beyond a concept. Production payment performance, active-user totals, and sales should be documented separately before being represented as commercial traction.

An internal calibration review reports 206 stored captures, 75 labels from one reviewer, and 4,133 held-out asking-price predictions. Median absolute percentage error was 15.3%. This is an internal comparison against advertised prices, not evidence of accuracy against completed transactions. Exact agreement with the reviewer's overall labels was 38% across 72 scorable examples; the review found that those labels reflected purchase and risk judgments rather than independent estimates of market value. These results support continued testing, not a claim of validated overall accuracy. [1]

The next development priorities are broader evaluation across vehicle types and locations, independent reviewers, better explanations for low-confidence results, and more robust extraction when Marketplace changes. The team should track capture success, comparison quality, cost per evaluation, and user-reported usefulness. Controlled testing with active shoppers will determine which outputs help buyers and which need revision before wider promotion.

Intellectual Property and Responsible Operation

Potential defensibility comes from original software, evaluation methods, data-quality processes, and product-specific know-how. Patent filings, trademark registrations, third-party licenses, and contributor ownership arrangements require confirmation; the plan does not depend on an issued patent. Any accumulated data advantage must be built within applicable permissions and data-use rights.

Marketplace access and browser-store distribution create platform dependency. User-initiated capture, narrow permissions, and removal of phone numbers and email addresses from descriptions are existing design safeguards, but do not establish platform authorization. Priorities include review of platform terms, privacy and retention practices, payment disclosures, and rights to external data. Environmental impact is indirect: helping buyers assess existing vehicles may support reuse, but no measured environmental benefit is claimed.

Market and Competitive Position

Target Market and Customers

The initial customer is a United States buyer actively comparing private-party vehicles on Facebook Marketplace using desktop Chrome. The strongest starting segments are first-time buyers, students and early-career consumers, and value-conscious households seeking a replacement vehicle. The common need is a usable shortlist and a clearer basis for asking questions. Frequent vehicle shoppers may become a secondary segment once usage patterns and support requirements are understood.

Cox Automotive's December 2025 forecast projected 38.3 million United States used-vehicle sales in 2026, down 0.9% from 2025. This provides a broad transaction benchmark rather than a count of Curbside prospects. It includes channels and buyers the initial product cannot serve. Curbside's opportunity therefore rests on serving an existing, substantial market more effectively, rather than assuming rapid industry growth. [2]

An illustrative serviceable-market scenario assumes 5% of those annual transactions correspond to a shopping episode reachable through the initial platform, browser, and customer focus. That produces approximately 1.915 million potential episodes. At \$12 of average revenue per paying episode and universal payment, the theoretical revenue pool would be about \$23 million annually. Neither the 5% reach assumption nor universal payment is established; actual revenue depends on reach and conversion. This scenario is a planning framework, not a measured market size.

The first-year operating target is 10,000 activated shoppers and 500 paying customers. That represents approximately 0.52% and 0.026%, respectively, of the illustrative serviceable episode count, assuming one episode per customer. Interviews and acquisition tests should replace these assumptions with evidence about desktop usage, Marketplace shopping behavior, and the proportion of buyers who need more than ten evaluations.

Competitors and Substitutes

Kelley Blue Book offers vehicle values, including private-party values, and benefits from an established automotive brand. CarGurus offers a valuation tool and deal ratings based on market comparisons. CARFAX provides vehicle-history reports that address a different but important part of purchase diligence. Manual research, advice from knowledgeable friends, and a mechanic's inspection are additional substitutes or complements. [3-5]

Free valuation and listing research create a meaningful price hurdle for Curbside. Its paid offer must justify \$7.99 to \$16.99 through convenience and useful listing-specific context. Curbside's proposed advantage is the integration of comparisons, risk explanations, and next steps directly into Marketplace browsing. It should not claim superior valuation accuracy or broader historical coverage without independent evidence. Competitor market shares within this narrow workflow have not been established, so no percentage-based leadership claim is made.

Competitive Advantage

The near-term distinction is workflow fit: a buyer can assess a listing where the shopping decision begins. Longer-term differentiation would come from consistently useful explanations, reliable extraction, better comparison filtering, and a feedback process that improves results. These capabilities may become harder to reproduce as evidence and expertise accumulate, but the current feature set is reproducible. A sustainable advantage must be earned through demonstrated quality, customer trust, and efficient distribution rather than asserted from the presence of software alone.

Sales Strategy and Business Model

Distribution and Customer Acquisition

The initial distribution path is the Chrome Web Store supported by the Curbside website. Marketing should demonstrate an actual evaluation, explain its limits, and guide an active shopper to a first successful result. The strongest message is concrete: understand a listing's price context and identify questions before contacting the seller. Demonstrations should use permitted examples and avoid claims of guaranteed savings or fraud detection.

The proposed launch begins with buyer interviews and a small pilot recruited through university networks, automotive communities that permit promotion, and personal referrals. Educational content can address common purchase questions and show how to compare similar vehicles. Relationships with independent mechanics and automotive educators could provide feedback and introductions; these are proposed channels, not existing partnerships. Paid campaigns should follow evidence that users activate and purchase at an economical rate.

The first-year planning funnel is 50,000 qualified website visits, 10,000 activated shoppers, and 500 paying customers. This assumes 20% visitor-to-activation conversion and 5% activated-to-paid conversion. Activation means completing a usable evaluation, not simply installing the extension. Each assumption needs measurement by channel. The team should also track repeat evaluations, free-credit consumption, time to purchase, refund requests, and how customers use results.

Revenue Model

Current product pricing specifies ten free evaluations on sign-up, a ten-check pack for \$7.99, a twenty-check pack for \$11.99, and an unlimited monthly plan for \$16.99. Purchased pack credits do not expire. This structure matches an episodic purchase: customers can pay for the amount of shopping support they need without a required long-term commitment. Prices are product settings, not evidence of customers' acceptance. [6]

The initial model assumes an average of \$12 in revenue per paying customer during a year, reflecting a mix of pack purchases and short subscription periods. It deliberately avoids assuming that a car buyer remains subscribed for twelve months. Usage limits, support demands, payment costs, and the cost of serving free users must be measured before the team can establish dependable margins.

Costs and Financial Discipline

Principal cash costs are hosting and storage, external model usage, payment processing, support, product maintenance, and customer acquisition. Some qualitative content can be cached, but total costs still depend on traffic and usage. The proposed first-year cash budget is \$12,000: \$3,000 for infrastructure and data services, \$4,000 for acquisition experiments, \$2,000 for specialist review, \$2,000 for reliability and support, and \$1,000 for contingency. These are planning allowances, not current spending.

With 500 paying customers and \$6,000 in revenue, the first-year scenario produces a \$6,000 cash deficit before founder compensation and taxes. Spending the entire \$4,000 acquisition allowance to obtain 500 payers implies an \$8 blended acquisition cost, before accounting for unpaid founder effort. Against \$12 in revenue per payer, that leaves little room for other costs. The business therefore needs low-cost distribution, higher revenue per shopping episode, or stronger conversion before scaling paid acquisition.

Revenue could begin as soon as production checkout, fulfillment, and the paid customer experience are verified. The proposed first 90 days focus on obtaining and studying initial paid purchases. This is a target rather than a forecast of demand. Current monthly burn and actual revenue remain [insert verified amounts].

Team Financial Outlook and Goals

Management Team

[Founder name, degree program, and relevant experience] leads the venture. The existing product provides evidence of execution, but the final submission should identify who built it and describe relevant technical, automotive, customer-research, or business experience. Academic advisor: [name]. External advisors: [names or none]. Capital received and sources: [verified amount and source, or none].

The proposed operating structure keeps product development and customer learning close to the founder while seeking targeted help in vehicle valuation, independent quality review, platform and privacy matters, and acquisition. Early needs can be addressed through advisors or limited specialist engagements before permanent hiring. A monthly review of customer feedback, errors, and acquisition results will guide changes in features, pricing, and spending.

Illustrative Financial Outlook

The following scenarios cover the first three full operating years. They are planning assumptions, not historical results or approved budgets. Revenue equals annual paying customers multiplied by \$12 average annual revenue per payer. Expenditure includes cash operating costs; founder salary, taxes, and financing are excluded. Expansion in Years 2 and 3 depends on evidence of conversion and product quality.

US dollars unless noted	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Activated shoppers	10,000	40,000	100,000
Paying customers at 5%	500	2,000	5,000
Revenue	6,000	24,000	60,000
Cash expenditure	12,000	24,000	42,000
Cash surplus or deficit	(6,000)	0	18,000

Average monthly expenditure is \$1,000, \$2,000, and \$3,500 across the three years. At 2% first-year conversion, revenue falls to \$2,400 and the deficit rises to \$9,600 if spending stays at \$12,000. At 10%, revenue reaches \$12,000 and covers that cash budget. This sensitivity makes conversion and spending discipline the central financial questions.

Competition Goals and Milestones

Curbside seeks pilot customers, automotive expertise, distribution introductions, and [confirm funding amount] in non-dilutive support. An illustrative \$10,000 award would support \$3,000 of infrastructure and data work, \$3,000 of acquisition tests, \$2,000 of specialist review, and \$2,000 of reliability work and contingency. This allocation would fund part of the operating budget; it is not additional expenditure.

Within 30 days, the proposed goals are 20 buyer interviews, a 25-person pilot, and verified payment and credit fulfillment. By day 90, target 100 activated shoppers and the first ten paid purchases, while recording usability and accuracy concerns. By month six, use observed conversion, acquisition cost, and evaluation quality to decide whether to broaden promotion. The first-year target is 500 paying customers, with expansion conditional on results rather than a fixed hiring schedule.

Sources

[1] Curbside internal calibration review, docs/calibration-pass-1.md; historical internal results, not independently audited.

[2] Cox Automotive, 2026 Forecasts, December 2025: coxautoinc.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/12/Q4-2025-Cox-Automotive-Industry-Insights-and-2026-Forecast-Call-Presentation.pdf

[3] Kelley Blue Book: kbb.com/whats-my-car-worth/ [4] CarGurus: cargurus.com/research/car-valuation [5] CARFAX: carfax.com/vehicle-history-reports/

[6] Curbside product pricing, curbside-app/lib/plans.ts. Public sources accessed September 29, 2026.